Trust is key in an open organisation

Getting staff to talk to each other ought to be the least of your problems, but internal communication can be one of the hardest nuts to crack in business. 'Communication comes up in every department. The repercussions of not communicating are vast.' Says Theo Theobald, co-author of Shut up and listen.' The Truth about how to communicate at work.'

Poor communication can be a purely practical problem. Gearbulk, a global shipping business with branches around the world, faced language and geographical difficulties, as well as a huge amount of paperwork. With up to 60 documents per cargo, it was a logistical nightmare to track and monitor jobs. While tighter security regulations after 9/11 meant customs documents had to be ready before a ship was allowed to sail.

Installing an automated system means data is now entered only once but can be accessed by anyone in the company, wherever they are. 'Reporting is faster by a matter of months', says Ramon Ferrer. Vice President of Global IT at Gearbulk. 'An operational team carrying a voyage all the way across the world doesn't always have to be talking to each other- and we don't waste time duplicating the same information.'

Given today's variety of communication tools, it seems strange that we still have a problem communicating. But the brave new world of high-tech can create barriers-senior managers hide behind their computers, staff use voice mail to screen calls, and employees sitting next to each other will send e-mails rather than speak.

'Managers should get up, walk round the office and talk to people,' says Matt Rogan, Head of Marketing at Lane4, a leadership and communications consultancy. 'Face-to-face communication can't be beaten.'

Theobold recommends checking e-mail only three times a day, allocating a set period of time to deal with it. 'If you leave the sound on, the temptation is as great as a ringing phone. People will interrupt meetings to check their their e-mails. Another problem is simply hitting the 'reply all' button, bombarding people with information. 'We had unstructured data coming at staff from left, right and centre, leaving it up to individuals to sort out, ' says Gearbulk's Ferrer. 'Our new system has reduced e-mails and changed the way people work. It will remind you about work flow'.

Information overload also means people stop listening. But there may be a deeper reason why a message fails to get through, according to Alex Haslam, Professor of Psychology at Exeter University. 'Everyone thinks a failure to communicate is just an individual's error of judgment, but it's not about the person: it's about the group and the group dynamics,' he says. 'Just training people to be good communicators isn't the issue.'

The problem is that employees develop common loyalties that are far stronger than the need to share information. This can even extend to questions of safety. In the mid 1990s there were a lot of light air crashes in Australia because the two government departments responsible for air safety weren't communicating,' says Haslam. 'The government was trying to save money and both groups felt threatened. The individuals were highly identified with their own organisation and unwilling to communicate with the other department.'

A company is particularly at risk when cost-cutting is in the air. Individuals withdraw into departmental loyalties out of fear. Sending such people on yet another 'how to communicate' course will be pointless. Instead, Haslam believes that identifying the sub-groups within an organisation and making sure each group feels valued and respected can do far more to encourage the sharing of information. The key to communication, he says, is trust.

From the Financial Times

10-We offer training programs.....are customized for each client.

a-that b-because c-since

11-He took a taxi to the reception because he expected that no parking spaces.....available.

a-would be b-be c-will be

12-.....of the product specifications have already been approved by the engineering department.

a-Most b-Less c-Mostly

13-The trade agrrement.....to improve the Brazilian industrial output.

a-are expected b-is expected c-was expected

**II-Put in the right tense or form: (3pts)**

I.....(apply) for my MA course while was working in Africa, and even managed to start doing some.....(search) before I came back to England. The work was quite..... (various) and I.....(give) different tasks to complete each week,..... (use) main aim was to educate local people about the reforestation. We tried putting up posters but this ..... (not have) much effect.

**III-Express differently and begin as shown (1.5pts)**

a-It was not necessary for you to seek help from a stranger.

→You needn't.....

b-I did not come because you did not invite me.

→If.....

c-You won't succeed unless you work harder.

→Provided.....

**IV-Turn into passive (1pt)**

a-Scientists carry out experiments in highly specialised labs.

→.....

b-Has someone posted my parcel?

→.....

555F

**AVIS IMPORTANT AUX ETUDIANTS**

1. Chacune des feuilles de votre copie doit comporter une étiquette code à barres placée à l'endroit indiqué «coller ici votre code à barres».
2. Une copie d'examen comporte une seule «feuille principale» et des «feuilles suites». Sur chacune de vos feuilles, le code à barres est obligatoire.
3. Cette feuille d'examen est strictement personnelle. Elle ne doit comporter aucun signe distinctif. Elle doit être écrite en noir et/ou bleu.
4. Le non respect de l'une de ces recommandations peut faire attribuer la note ZERO à l'épreuve.

**NOTE**

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| Durée : 1h | D_S | Documents non autorisés |

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## Reading Comprehension

**I-Read the article and complete the table below: (2.5pts)**

| Communication problems | | |
|---|---|---|
| A-High tech | B- Information overload | C-Common loyalties |
| Consequences | Consequence | Consequence |
| ..... | ..... | ..... |
| ..... | | |
| ..... | | |

**II-Answer these questions (1.5pts)**

a-What communication problems did Gearbulk have?

.....

b-According to the author, why do staff often receive too many e-mails?

.....

c-What does the author think about sending people on communication courses?

.....

**III-Which word in each group does not form a word partnership with the word in bold? (1,5)**

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1-duplicate** | information | time | work |
| **2-install** | systems | factories | equipment |
| **3-allocate** | time | ideas | resources |

**IV-Give synonyms to these expressions:** (1,5pts)

Unintended consequences of an event or action: (parag1) .....

The desire to do something: (parag6).....

To cover a wider area, make larger: (parag8).....

**V-"Face-to-face communication can't be beaten". Do you agree? Develop your opinion in two lines ( 1pt)**

.....

.....

## Language

**I-Choose the right alternative, circle it: (6.5pts)**

1-Karen's really.....these days. You never know if she's going to be cheerful or bad temper.

a-sensitive b-moody c-reliable

2-Look at that fabulous present Hiro gave me, I can't believe his.....!

a-generous b-genious c-generousity

3-Are you sure you want to share a flat with Nicole? You're so messy, but she's famous for her.....

a-tidiness b-tidy c-tidying

4-They.....hardly have imagined that in 1969 a man would be landed on the moon.

a-should b-must c-could

5-Not only.....being used for scientific research in space but also to see what kind of weather is coming.

a-are they b-they are c-there are

6-It's no use .....to learn a language just by studying a dictionary.

a-trying b-to try c-in trying

7-Many dentists say that chewing sugar-free gum is good.....your teeth.

a-to b-for c-in

8-In addition to built in salary increases, everyone .....provided insurance benefits.

a-were b-was c-is

9-The successful candidate should have a strong background in economics.....business studies.

a-but b-and c-so